

Special Needs Adult Transition Planning Checklist Worksheet

A step-by-step planning worksheet for parents and families preparing a child with disabilities for adulthood — from childhood through age 18 and beyond.

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How to use this worksheet: Work through one section at a time. Check each box as you gather a document or finish a step, and write in the lines as things change. Keep the finished worksheet with your important documents — and bring it whenever you meet with a school, agency, doctor, or advocate.

Part 1 — My Child's Current Information

Child's full name	
Date of birth	
Diagnoses / conditions	
School & grade	
Health insurance	
Main doctors	
Current medications	
Therapies (OT / PT / Speech / ABA)	
Case manager / coordinator	
Emergency contact	

Part 2 — Important Documents Checklist

Keep copies of all of these together, in one safe place.

- ☐ Birth certificate
- ☐ Social Security card
- ☐ Health insurance cards
- ☐ Proof of citizenship
- ☐ Contact list for all doctors and providers
- ☐ Current medication list
- ☐ Hospital and surgery history
- ☐ Immunization records
- ☐ Therapy evaluations and progress notes (OT, PT, Speech, ABA)

- ☐ Letters of medical necessity for equipment or services
- ☐ IEPs (Individualized Education Programs)
- ☐ 504 Plans
- ☐ Testing and evaluations (IQ, adaptive behavior, school evaluations)
- ☐ Behavior plans
- ☐ Transition assessments (these should begin at age 14)

Part 3 — Age-18 Planning Checklist

Turning 18 changes the rules. Start these steps early so nothing is a surprise.

By age 14

- ☐ Transition planning is part of the IEP, with real goals for adulthood
- ☐ Transition assessments are being done and saved

By ages 16-17

- ☐ Decide how decisions will be made at 18: Supported Decision-Making, limited guardianship, or full guardianship (only if necessary)
- ☐ Apply for Texas waiver interest lists if you have not already (see Part 5 — waitlists are long)
- ☐ Learn how SSI counts income and resources for an adult

In the year before 18

- ☐ Gather medical and school records for the SSI application
- ☐ Open a bank account for SSI payments
- ☐ Plan the application for adult Medicaid
- ☐ Review insurance and beneficiary forms that name your child

At 18

- ☐ SSI is reviewed again under adult rules (redetermination) — be ready with records
- ☐ Apply for adult Medicaid
- ☐ Update school, doctors, and agencies that your child is now a legal adult

Part 4 — Social Security (SSI) Planning

At 18, your child may qualify for SSI as an adult. Here is what Social Security will need:

- ☐ Medical records showing the condition and how it limits daily life
- ☐ School records — IEPs, evaluations, and teacher reports
- ☐ Function reports: how the disability affects daily living skills, communication, behavior, learning, safety, and supervision needs
- ☐ Proof of income and resources
- ☐ A bank account in place for SSI payments
- ☐ Medical care stays current — keep going to appointments and keep records updated
- ☐ I understand the SSI rules: income limits, resource limits, ABLE accounts, and trusts

Tip: How your child's disability affects everyday life is critical for SSI, Medicaid, and waiver programs. Write down real examples as they happen — dates, what happened, and what help was needed.

Part 5 — Benefits & Resources Checklist

Medicaid

- ☐ My child stays enrolled in Medicaid
- ☐ Annual Medicaid renewals are completed on time
- ☐ We will apply for adult Medicaid at 18
- ☐ We understand Medicaid Buy-In if my child is working

Texas Medicaid Waivers — apply as early as possible; waitlists can be years long

- ☐ HCS (Home and Community-based Services)
- ☐ CLASS (Community Living Assistance and Support Services)
- ☐ DBMD (Deaf Blind with Multiple Disabilities)
- ☐ TxHmL (Texas Home Living)

Waiver(s) applied for &
dates _____

Behavioral supports — keep copies of:

- ☐ Behavior plans
- ☐ Behavioral evaluations
- ☐ Crisis plans
- ☐ ABA records

Part 6 — Employment & Vocational Planning

- ☐ Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) services explored
- ☐ Supported employment options reviewed
- ☐ Job coaching considered
- ☐ Job training or vocational programs identified
- ☐ College disability support offices contacted (if college is a goal)
- ☐ Project SEARCH or similar programs looked into
- ☐ Work incentives understood — how working affects SSI/SSDI
- ☐ VR funding for training or education explored

My child's work / program
interests _____

Part 7 — Daily-Living Skills

Skills we are practicing together (check each one as it grows):

- ☐ Money management — budgeting, paying, making change
- ☐ Personal safety at home and in the community

- ☐ Hygiene and self-care
- ☐ Cooking simple meals
- ☐ Using transportation
- ☐ Self-advocacy — speaking up for needs and choices

Transportation options to explore

- ☐ Paratransit services
- ☐ Medicaid transportation
- ☐ Accessible rideshare options
- ☐ Driving evaluation (if driving may be possible)

Part 8 — Financial Planning

The right setup protects your child's benefits. Consider each of these:

- ☐ Special Needs Trust discussed (first-party, third-party, or pooled) — work with a special needs attorney
- ☐ ABLE account opened — save for housing, transportation, education, and medical needs without losing SSI
- ☐ We avoid giving money or assets directly to our child in ways that could hurt benefits
- ☐ Life insurance and beneficiary forms updated
- ☐ Letter of Intent (care plan) written — routines, likes, needs, and wishes for future caregivers
- ☐ Housing plan started: Section 8, supported living, home modifications, or future care when parents can no longer provide it
- ☐ Emergency plan ready: emergency go-bag, crisis plan, one-page medical summary, registration with local emergency programs

Part 9 — Questions to Ask Before Adulthood

Talk these through as a family and write your answers. There are no wrong answers — having a plan is what matters.

Who will help my child make decisions as an adult?

Where will my child live as an adult?

What benefits will my child have at 18 — and what must we do to protect them?

Who is on our team (doctors, school, case manager, attorney, advocate)?

What is our emergency plan if something happens to us?

What will fill my child's days — work, program, or school?

What happens when we can no longer provide care?

Part 10 — What Do I Need To Do Next?

Turn your checklists into action. List your next steps here — one at a time.

#	Next step	By when	Done
1			☐
2			☐
3			☐
4			☐
5			☐
6			☐
7			☐
8			☐

Need help with any of these steps? Southern Oak Financial & Wellness guides families through SSA applications, medication assistance, and life insurance — in plain language, at your pace. Email us at supporthelpsofw@gmail.com or visit southernoakfw.org.

Please read: This worksheet is an educational planning tool only. It is not legal, tax, medical, or financial advice, and Southern Oak Financial & Wellness is not a law firm and does not provide legal representation. Special needs trusts, guardianship, and supported decision-making should be set up with a qualified attorney. Benefit rules change and vary by program and situation. There is no guarantee of approval for any benefit, waiver, or program — the agencies and programs make those decisions. Timelines, including waiver waitlists, vary. This worksheet is for your family's personal use only.